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Insight

SETTLING DIFFERENCES

Any Linux geek would tell you Linux thrashes Windows in more ways than one. But does it? And why? What makes a system better than another? At this stage, are they even different at all?

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If there were no Windows vs. Linux battles, the geek life would have been notably duller. Technology forums would inevitably get boring, and life would generally never be the same. The most contentious issue, of course, is security—Windows is notorious for not having much in that department. However, Vista is loaded with a bunch of new security measures, and claims to be able to thwart malicious software better.

What makes an operating system more secure? The way it's built, of course. And *that* is the question we're asking. But first, some myth-busting.

Popularity Contest

The favourite theory to explain the low number of viruses (or Trojans, or other such malicious code, for that matter) that exist for Linux is that it's not popular enough—they say

that if you turned the tables and made Linux the world's most used OS, you'd find just as many malicious programs for it as you do for Windows now.

There is some logic to both the statements, but here's what the Linux community usually comes back with: nearly half of the world's Web sites run on Apache, either on Linux or a BSD. Since this is obviously the most popular platform, there's plenty of incentive for hackers to spend their time taking it down—and yet, you don't see Apache's vulnerabilities in the news as much as you see those of Microsoft's IIS. Not that the hackers aren't trying to take down Apache servers—they're just not having as much success with it as they are with IIS servers.

